# Method section checklist



WRITER'S CODE _____ READER'S CODE _____ DATE _____

**What College Board asks of this section:** it "explains and provides justification for the chosen method, process, or approach and its alignment with the research question." Two verbs, **explain** and **justify**, and one test, **alignment**.

## EXPLAIN: COULD A READER REPEAT IT?

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| ☐ | **Who or what.** Who or what was studied, how many, and how they were chosen. |
| ☐ | **Instrument.** The survey, interview guide, dataset, or texts are described. The full instrument is in an appendix. |
| ☐ | **Steps.** What was done, in order, with dates and how long each part took. |
| ☐ | **Analysis.** How the data was analyzed, named plainly: counts, a comparison, coding for themes. |

## ETHICS: IS IT ON THE PAGE?

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| ☐ | **Approval.** Says the study was approved before any data was collected. |
| ☐ | **Consent and privacy.** Says how people agreed to take part and how their identities are protected. For public data: says no participants were contacted. |

## JUSTIFY: WHY THIS, AND NOT SOMETHING ELSE?

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| ☐ | **Alignment.** One or two sentences connect the method to the research question in the writer's own words. |
| ☐ | **The road not taken.** Names at least one other method and gives a reason it was not used. |
| ☐ | **A methods source.** Cites a methods text or a published study for the choice. A blog or infographic does not count. |
| ☐ | **Limits.** Names what this method cannot show. Small sample, one school, one year, self-report. |

## EVIDENCE: CAN IT BE TRACED?

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| ☐ | **Every number.** Each number in the section matches the writer's own data file. |
| ☐ | **Nothing borrowed.** No number, example, or wording comes from a sample paper or a template. |

## READER: ONE PLACE I COULD NOT FOLLOW (ASK A QUESTION; DO NOT REWRITE IT)

## WRITER: WHAT I WILL CHANGE, IN MY OWN WORDS

**Readers ask questions and point to gaps. They do not write, rewrite, or suggest wording. The paper is the writer's own work.**